

A Core Where His Heart Was

Saelunere, Episode Seven

Parvo, in the year 756

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It happened in an instant, faster than Billiam could have processed it. Nearly eight feet of twisted flesh and machinery surged across the yard, covering the distance to him in a single stride. Its hulking frame was a grotesque marriage of muscle and iron, with salvaged plates riveted directly into its body and thick metal bands constricting its limbs. Beneath its breastbone, an essence core burned with a green light, casting sickly reflections across the exposed mechanisms embedded in its chest.

Only moments earlier, it had been packed inside a wooden crate, lashed to the back of a cart and delivered to the scrapyards by two strangers who had arrived without warning.

The rest of the group was a hundred feet off at the far end of the yard, behind a shut door, and had heard a noise.

Billiam reacted on instinct, thrusting a hand forward as a shimmering barrier of force materialised between him and the descending fist. The impact struck the invisible wall with a thunderous crack, sending a tremor through the air but

leaving him standing.¹

Then the second one came.

He got the hand up again and there was nothing behind it this time. The blow caught him across the head and threw him into the scrap piled beside the gate, and his neck went with it, and he crumpled among the wreckage and did not move.

Billiam was dead. He was nineteen. He had been standing at his own gate asking a man for delivery papers.

The creature did not stop to look at what it had done. It came down off the step and walked over him without once altering its stride, and went on up the yard towards the office at the far end.

Rain started to pour down.

* * *

Aeska opened the office door onto it.

Every one of them had heard it, a noise at the far end of the yard like thunder laid flat along the ground. He got the door open and there was eight feet of flesh and iron coming up the middle of the yard at him.

“There’s a big metal construct walking towards us.” He said it back over his shoulder into the room. “Be careful.”

Aeska’s gaze fixed on the iron bands encircling the creature’s chest. He thrust out his hand, and the metal began to glow, its surface shifting from dull grey to a furious orange beneath the rain.²

Lark came out of the door past Aeska and ran.

The yard at Claringbold’s stretched a hundred and twenty feet from gate to office, and Lark crossed it at a run, weaving through the rain and around the creature’s path. She tried to catch its gaze as she passed, expecting it to turn on her, or at least acknowledge her presence. Instead, its head remained fixed on the office ahead. Startled by the disregard, she yelled at everyone to watch out. Then she reached Billiam.

“Billy!”

¹**Shield.** Thrown up in the half second before a blow lands rather than prepared in advance, and gone again as soon as the moment has passed. It is the only working most casters learn that is purely an answer to something already happening.

²**Heat Metal.** Exactly what it sounds like, and one of the cruellest things in common use. The metal glows, and whatever is touching it has to let go. A man drops his sword. A thing with the metal riveted into its own ribs cannot.

He was lying on his side in the scrap with his eyes wide open. She was still shouting his name when she got to him, and she went down on her knees in the wet and got both hands on his face, and then she saw the angle his neck was at and the cold went through her all at once.

“Billy. Billy, come on.”

She put her hands on his head and the warm light came up through them into him, and she pushed everything she had after it. Just like Theodore, there was nothing in there for it to hold on to.

“Billy. I’ll come back for you.” The sob came up out of her with no tears in it. Then she was on her feet and running back up the yard at the creature. It was going for the others now.

Shepherd the construct came clumping over on his three legs and put his lamp head down and nudged him, and then nudged him again.

* * *

The creature continued towards Aeska, who stood in the office doorway. Aeska shouted, and the sound came out of his throat broken and wrong and struck the creature like something thrown. It was a blow, and it landed. The creature took it and kept walking, its head never turning.

Its attention was fixed on Felix.

Felix had stepped out into the yard. The moment he saw the creature, something in his expression changed. He stared at it, recognition and dread passing over his face before he muttered, almost to himself, *oh god, not another one*. And he put a column of silver light down on top of it.³

The creature walked into the silver light and came out the other side of it as though it had not been there, closing the distance to Felix. Its right arm extended, and from its hand uncoiled a length of chain, ending in a heavy, curved hook.

Felix went sideways and the hook went past him into the wall.

After that Calder, Aeska and Felix took it apart between the window and the doorway, in a room too small for any of it, while the iron in its own chest cooked it from the inside and it could not get its hand on the one person in the yard it had been sent for. Calder put a bolt of fire through the window into its chest and then another. Aeska broke the air round it twice and hit it with a hard shove of sound that took it off its feet and into a wall. Felix summoned a sword of fire into

³**Moonbeam.** A shaft of cold silver light dropped over a space, which stays where it is put and burns whatever stands in it. There is no moon over Parvo. It comes down anyway.

his own hand and swung it and came within an inch of its neck. The iron in the creature's chest went on melting.

It got down onto one knee with its hand still out towards Felix.

"He's almost dead." Aeska had his back against the doorframe, and he looked across the room at Calder.

Calder came across the room, put himself at Aeska's shoulder, and sent three darts of light through the side of the creature's head.⁴

They went in through the ear. Something let go inside the skull, and it slid forward onto its face and did not move again.

The rain came down on the yard.

"Billy's dead." Lark was at the door with the rain coming off her. "Billy's dead!"

* * *

They came out and found Shepherd dragging him.

The construct had got its lamp housing under the boy's arm and was hauling him back up the yard towards the office a foot at a time, bumping him over the rubble, because the last clear instruction Billiam ever gave it was to look after the place.

Calder got to him first. No breath. No pulse. His neck was twisted, which was a grim sight and sealed the current fate of him.

Then Felix said something that changed the afternoon.

"That thing. It has a core in his chest, like I do."

He had been staring at the hulking mass of flesh and machinery they had just killed when the thought struck him, sudden and complete. Fifteen seconds. Perhaps twenty. That was all the time Billiam had been dead.

"Get his body inside."

* * *

The office had been wrecked twice in two days and now it had two bodies in it.

They put Billiam on the desk. Aeska went and crouched over the creature on

⁴**Magic Missile.** Three bolts of force thrown from the hand, which do not need to be aimed and cannot be dodged. Every apprentice learns it, and it is the only attack in the book that is simply guaranteed.

the floor and looked at the hole in its chest where the light was going out. Three years at the Guild of Engineers was enough to tell him what he was looking at, and it took him under a minute to understand all of it.

Someone had taken a dead man and opened him up. They had set an essence core in the place where his heart should have been, then gone further, repairing whatever had been wrong with his body and altering it until it could do more than it ever had in life. The work had not been done with care for the man beneath it. Every cut, every alteration, every piece of machinery forced into flesh spoke of the same brutal indifference. Nothing about it had been gentle.

“So.” Calder was already pulling things off the desk and onto the floor to clear it. “You were alive, Felix. Billy has barely passed away. He’s still warm.”

“They did it to me while I was awake,” Felix said. “That was the difficult part. That was the thing they were pleased about.”

“And on a man who has just died?”

“I don’t know. It might be easier.” He was looking at Billiam on the desk. “It might be a great many other things.”

“How long do we have?”

“I don’t know that either.” Felix wiped the rain off his face with his forearm and left it no cleaner. “Not long.”

“I am afraid I have no knowledge or experience in any of this.” Aeska had both hands flat on the desk on either side of Billiam. “However. I suggest that this might be a last resort.”

Lark stood to one side, one hand over her mouth, fingers curled towards her teeth. The other hand hovered close to Billiam’s arm, as though she wanted to feel the little warmth he had left.

Calder knelt beside the desk with a dagger in his hand. He had never performed surgery in his life, but he had the anatomy out of a textbook and he knew where things were. He made the first cut down the centre of the chest and the second across it, so the skin would come back in four corners, and he kept his eyes on the work and not on the familiar boy beneath his hands.

Then he went in and took the heart out, and held on to it, because there was nowhere in that room to put it down.

Felix retrieved the essence core from the hulking corpse in the next room, working it free from the melted iron around it. He handled it with a care that had been absent from everything else.

Aeska took the core and started placing it in Billiam’s chest. Three years of essence engineering had taught him how a core functioned, if not how to perform the operation he was attempting. He removed what had stopped working and fitted the new heart into its place.

It was not a clean job, and essentially seemed impossible to work. But beneath Aeska's hands, the core began to glow.

* * *

The next half-minute unfolded in a chaos none of them had any hope of controlling.

As the essence core settled into Billiam's chest, something in his blood answered it. His magic, usually so unpredictable even at its weakest, erupted with a force that seemed to have no end. Wild surges coursed through him, each one feeding into the next, spilling out into the room and dragging the three men bent over him into its wake.⁵

Calder, Felix and Aeska felt their strength drain away, as though some unseen force were drawing the very vitality from their bodies and pouring it into Billiam. Their knees threatened to buckle, but none of them fell.

Around them, the room began to lose its hold on reality. Their outlines wavered, bodies flickering between presence and absence, while the desk and the dead boy beneath their hands remained stubbornly fixed. Lark could only watch, frozen beside them, as the air seemed to fold and distort around the four figures.

Whatever was happening, it was no longer something they could interrupt. The magic had taken hold, and Billiam lay at its centre, beyond the reach of anything that might have stopped it.

They came back into the room in the places they had been standing. Billiam was convulsing on the desk with his chest open. Whoever had healing put it into him, all of them at once, and the edges of the wound drew together beneath their hands, flesh closing with an unnatural, almost reluctant precision, as though his body were being forced to accept a shape it no longer remembered.

Billiam took a breath.

It went into him all the way and he arched off the desk with it. Then he got a hand up and put his own neck back where it belonged, which made a noise, and opened his eyes.

Calder was standing over him holding his heart.

"Welcome back," said Felix.

⁵**Wild magic.** Billiam does not cast so much as permit. Something comes up out of him alongside the working and does whatever it is going to do, and the bracelet on his wrist takes the edge off it when it can. On a table with an essence core going into his chest, the bracelet was nowhere near enough.

* * *

“Are you alive?” Lark grabbed the edge of the table and stood on her toes towards Billiam. “Can you breathe?”

“I...”

“Do you recognise us?” She was going too fast to be stopped. “You’re normal. Say something. You’re not like, monster.”

“Monster?” Billiam was looking at the ceiling. “Wait. Where am I?”

“You’re in the office, Billy.”

“What happened?”

“Oh, fucking hell.” Aeska had sat down on the floor with his back against the desk and both hands up away from himself, bloody to the wrist. “Well. Welcome back to life, I guess.”

Calder held out the heart.

“I guess this is yours.”

Billiam looked at it for a while.

“What do you mean, revive me? I wasn’t dead. I was just knocked out, right?”

“You were dead.”

“No. It’s not possible.”

“Did you feel anything?” Calder had not put the heart down. “Did it feel like a dream, or sleep? Did you see darkness, or light?”

“I did see some form of light.” He said it slowly, finding it. “It was getting closer. And I could feel the warmth. But then it was like it got taken away from me. And the light moved away. And then I woke up.”

Nobody had an answer for that one.

When he looked down, a ragged incision crossed his chest, its edges already drawing together. He had no memory of anyone cutting him open. Under the skin there was a green glow.

There was no heartbeat. The essence core had taken over the work of his heart, keeping blood moving through his veins without the familiar thud beneath his ribs. He still had a pulse, and a cut would still make him bleed.

None of them knew what the alteration would mean for him in future. Not even Aeska, whose knowledge of essence engineering had brought Billiam back, could say what they had done to him in the long run.

Aeska went out of the office to get a breath of something that was not that room. He stood in the rain with his hands held out and let it wash the blood off them, and he looked at them for a long time, at the two hands that had just done that.

* * *

Two bodies lay in the road beneath the wreckage of a smashed cart. Felix went to see the scene.

Felix examined the wreckage scattered across the road. Moving a crate through Parvo was ordinary Porter's Guild work, yet neither man had worn the insignia or clothing of a Guild porter. Whoever they were, they had gone to considerable lengths to disguise themselves.

Among the carter's belongings, he found a folded note. A few feet away, half-hidden between the cobbles, lay a pocket watch, apparently thrown from the man's coat when the cart overturned.

A thin sliver of essence core had been set into the watch's mechanism. A muted green light seeped through the casing, barely visible beneath the grime and rain. The moment Felix picked it up, he sensed a faint, unfamiliar energy stirring within it. He could tell it was more than an ordinary timepiece.

The note said this.

Take this and deliver the crate nearby. See that it is delivered. Do not be seen doing it, do not linger, and do not stay to watch.

This piece comes back with you. It cannot be replaced in good order, and it is worth a great deal more than you are. If you lose it, do not come back at all.

Burn this note.

He dragged them both off the street and put them where the road would not show them. Then he stood the broken cart up against the wall. For a few hours anybody going past would read it as a breakdown and somebody gone for a wheelwright.

When Felix returned to the office, the others were gathered around the desk. He set the note and the watch down between them. As the watch settled against the wood, its needle shifted, turning steadily until it pointed directly at him.

"What if you put it closer to Billy?" Calder moved it across the desk. "Is the needle still pointing at Felix?"

Billiam had a core in his chest now as well. If the watch was looking for a core, it had two to pick from, and Calder had just put it nearer to Billiam's.

The needle did not move. They put the watch into Billiam's hand and it still

pointed at Felix.

"I think they were aiming for me," Felix said.

"Who's they?"

"I think they want me back."

* * *

So Felix began to tell them the rest of it, with the rain going on the roof.

"My parents took me there four years ago. South of the city. They brought an essence core with them." He had his eyes on a point somewhere past all of them. "After that I was under for three years. I woke up three times."

"The first time my chest was still open. I could see it in there." He said it the way you give somebody directions. "The second time it was closed and I was strapped into a chair and I couldn't turn my head. There was a scratcher in the room trying to get me loose. It was too late by then."

"And the third?"

"The third time I talked to a scratcher, and the scratcher brought Theo."

Nobody said anything for a moment.

"Did your parents sell you there?" Lark asked it quietly.

"To be honest, I have no idea."

"Did you have some health issue?" Calder was writing. "Was this a last option, or."

"I had no health issues." Felix did not look up. "It was more like I had no magic before."

"Who was there?" Aeska had come in from the rain with his sleeves pushed up. "Who did it?"

"A woman. She did all the talking, the times I was awake. There was a man as well, once, somewhere I couldn't see." He shrugged with one shoulder. "I never got a name for either of them."

"And the place?"

"Empty. Theo and I went back, once we'd worked out how." He looked up then. "They didn't clear it carefully. They left the day after I ran. It's in the Core, on the edge of the Furlong, and there's nothing in it."

"Mr Felix." Lark had been working something out. "Do you mean that they did this to you while you were alive?"

"Yes."

"And that it worked."

“That seemed to be the surprising part.” He was quiet about it. “They were very pleased. I remember that.”

Billiam was still lying on the desk, and he said nothing at all.

Whatever had been done to Felix, it was the same work that had been done to the creature lying dead on the office floor.

“I wonder if they want you alive, Mr Felix.” Lark was sitting on the desk by Billiam’s feet. “Or just the thing inside you.”

“They might want me alive. To test things again.”

“Just hope there aren’t many more of these.” He looked at the shape under the sheet on the floor. “Because then I’m definitely not safe.”

“And you shouldn’t be alone.” Calder shut the notebook. “I think we should just not split any more.”

* * *

They split up inside ten minutes of agreeing not to.

“I need to clean up and get some clothes.” Billiam was still sitting on the desk. “And probably rest for a bit.”

“Someone goes with him,” Lark said.

“I can do that,” said Calder. “But we would need to make a small tour. There is somewhere I have to be first.”

“Then I’ll take Mr Felix to the bathhouse with me, because I have to see Madame Rooke.” She was already picking up her bindle. “And you can have an actual bath, Mr Felix.”

“That would be nice.”

Aeska said he would go alone. He gave no reason, and nobody pressed him for one. An hour earlier, his hands had been inside a boy’s chest.

* * *

Salador’s Slip in the middle of the afternoon was lively compared to the evenings Lark had been there in the last few days. Now the entrance stood open, people were washing in the baths, and the noise rising from the ground floor was the rough conversation of a dozen old men on their break, all of them due back at work within the hour.

Delia was at the front desk.

"Oh." She looked up. "Hey. We don't normally see you this early on."

"Yeah, I decided to be nice to Madame Rooke today and come before her sleeping time." Lark put a thumb over her shoulder. "This is Mr Felix. He's going to take a bath."

"Just a bath," said Felix.

"Just a bath. It's a penny." Delia was already reaching for the box. "Towels round the corner, men's baths that way. Feel free to stay as long as you like. Don't make any trouble. I'm sure you won't."

Lark went up.

On the second flight, a girl hurried past her with her head down. She had just come from the room at the top of the stairs. Lark caught only a glimpse of her face as she passed, flushed and uneasy, before the girl disappeared down the stairs.

The door was still swinging when she reached it, and Madame Rooke saw her through the gap and beckoned her in.

"Lark."

"Hi. I'm here earlier today."

"Hopefully by my request." She put her pen down. "Yes. I believe I said I might be able to find you a task. One has fallen into our laps, so to speak. It is a delivery job, which I understand you have some experience of, and I will pay you two marks for it."

"I am good at deliveries!" Lark celebrated a bit too excitedly, and tapped her own arms to calm herself down.

"Mary, unfortunately, had to put in a complaint about a gentleman who came here last night."

Lark did not say anything at all, which for her is a considerable act of self-control.

"So you will deliver him a letter." Madame Rooke went back to writing it. "Whilst he is at work. His wife will be in the house. And you will make sure that she reads it."

"You simply need to ensure that he receives it. When he happens not to be in the house. And use your wiles to convince the lady that it could be important, and that she might wish to open the post and just check it before he gets home."

"Does he work regular hours?" Lark asked.

"He comes here in the evenings. I believe he works one of the forges in the Core, so he will be away most of the day." She folded the letter, put it in a cover and pressed her seal into the wax. "I would recommend you do not bump into him, before or after. I am sure you could come up with something. But I do not think he would take it kindly, if he found out what your intention is here."

“Yeah. Of course. This sounds perfect.” Lark took the letter.

“Tilbury is his name. Amos Tilbury. Just on the edge of the Core, not far from Oblong Square.” She gave the directions. “So it will be Mr and Mrs Tilbury. The intended recipient being Mrs Tilbury.”

Lark gave a determined nod and rushed out.

* * *

Lark went along the landing to Nell’s room and knocked, hoping to find her in this time.

“I’m so glad I caught you today.” Lark got the door shut behind her. “I had to leave last time. You were with a customer and I didn’t want to bother you. I got a job from Madame Rooke. I have it now, in my hands.”

“That’s so good.” Nell was sitting up on the bed with her feet under her. “I’m glad everything went well. With Madame Rooke, I thought, I don’t know, things might have been problematic. She’s been in a bit of an on and off mood.”

“Yeah.” Lark sat down. “And listen. I actually have a mission for you.”

“Oh my gods.” Nell put both hands over her mouth. “A mission.”

Lark gave her the names, Evan Langford, Sasha Langford, Theodore Blackwood, Volan and Gertrude, and a description of the Aela man whose name she did not know. She told Nell to keep her ears open. In a house where everyone talked, information had a way of travelling, but Nell would have to listen without making it obvious what she was looking for. Above all, she was not to let anyone realise she was asking questions.

“Yeah, no problem. I’m here all the time, I’ll listen out.” Nell waved it away. “I can be nonchalant. I’ve never been chaland in my life.”

“Thank you. Just don’t tell Madame Rooke.”

“But that’s what we do.” Nell looked genuinely confused. “Where do you think she gets all her information? We hear stuff and we tell her. That’s the whole thing.”

“Oh.” Lark sat back down on the bed.

“So if I hear about these people, do you want me to tell her, or keep it secret, or...?”

“You can tell Madame Rooke. But tell me too. And don’t tell her that you’re telling me.”

“Don’t tell her that you told me not to tell her,” Nell said wonderingly.

“Exactly.”

Nell frowned. “So I shouldn’t tell her that you told me to listen, or that I’m

telling you.”

“Yes.”

“But I should still tell her what I hear.”

“Yes.”

“While pretending I’m not telling you.”

“Yes.”

“And I’m not supposed to tell her that I’m doing that.”

“Correct.”

Nell nodded slowly, as though committing a complicated set of instructions to memory. Then her face brightened. “Wow! This is a big thing now.”

Lark went back down to the lobby to wait for Felix.

* * *

Billiam’s mother was at work, leaving the house empty. He let himself and Calder in with his own key and pulled off the ruined shirt. The green of the essence shed a little light through the scars on his chest, and he looked down at that for a while before he found himself a clean one.

Calder asked whether he could look through his father’s papers, and Billiam said he was welcome to and that there was no point, because Benjamin Buckman keeps everything either on him or at the office. Calder searched through the desk, checking each drawer and looking over the papers. There was nothing useful there. No notes, no unfinished work, no records of any kind. For a man who was rarely in the building, the desk was as empty as expected.

“Then we should try his office at the College,” Calder said. “I know where it is.”

“What are you looking for?”

“I don’t know. But he is part of this somehow. Any connector would be informative. Especially about the project he will not discuss. And he is connected to Aeska’s father.”

“He’s for sure hiding something.” Billiam was pulling the clean shirt over the scar. “He told me not to get involved. He’d only say that if he knew something.” He thought about it. “I don’t think it’s going to be easy to get into his office. I wouldn’t risk it. But you might be able to, since you’re actually at the College.”

They ate something, and sat down for a while, which both of them needed more than either said. Then they let themselves out and went on.



As Calder led Billiam down into the Bellows, Billiam followed with a nervousness, and at the same time a surprise at how easily his feet carried him back into the tunnels. The place he had sworn he would never go into again.

Calder knew the way without hesitation. As they descended, the familiar machinery faded behind them until only the echo of their footsteps remained.

Billiam stopped.

“Do you hear that?”

Tapping. A rhythm in it, and now and then a high whistle that anybody would take for a steam vent if they had not grown up anywhere near people who use it.

“That’s not just noise down here.” He kept his voice low. “That’s somebody talking.”

“Do you understand it?”

“No. But people are communicating. It might be about us.”

“That is very good to know.” Calder had slowed right down. “Very good to know.”

Two men came off the tunnel wall ahead of them and stood in the middle of it. One small Darkin, one much larger human in his late thirties with a cudgel held down by his leg.

Calder told Billiam to wait, and got a plain mask out of his pack and put it on. Billiam did not wait. He pulled his collar up over his face and walked with him.

“Hello, boys.” The small one had his hands in his pockets. “What are you two doing all the way out here?”

Billiam stepped in front of Calder before Calder had finished deciding what to say.

“What is it to you?” There was a crackle of something round him as he said it. “Why do you want to know?”

“Whoa.” The small man did not move. “We operate, let’s say, the informal toll system in the Bellows. You pay up, we let you through. You look like you’ve been down here before. You probably know how it works.”

Calder put a hand on Billiam’s shoulder.

“This is my new associate.” He said it levelly. “And I am sure that you know the names. Mister C. Mister K.”

The big man shoulder-checked him on the way past.

“I don’t know who these mister whoever, ABCD, what the fuck you are.” He had not raised his voice either. “You’re paying up. It’s two pennies each. Straight-forward.”

Calder stopped. He looked the man in the eye, and took out a mark, and tossed

it to him.

"The next time," he said, "it's better for you to remember."

They went on down the tunnel. Behind them, not quietly enough, the big man said *this idiot paid double, I don't think he realises*, and the two of them went off fast with the money before anybody could work out the arithmetic.

Billiam did not ask who Mister C was. It was the other name he kept turning over. Mister K. Calder had told him once never to say it out loud, that it was not a safe name to be heard using, and had now said it himself to two men in a tunnel without appearing to think twice about it.

The drop was a steam terminal in the tunnel wall, one of hundreds, picked in advance and not the one Calder usually uses. Inside it there was a scroll sealed with grey wax, and pressed into the wax, a moth.

He put it in his pocket and did not read it until they were back above ground.

Penn had been watching the building in the Outlines for two days and had nothing. Servants in and out. The family now and then. Valerin Volan leaving for the Engineers' spire in the morning and coming back at night, every day, like a man with a job.

Dunmore had worked the Porter's Guild as asked. Everyone knows there are people held in the spire; that is not news to anybody. But somebody had described a man taken in at about the right time, and the description was Shrapnel.

"There is some confirmation," Calder said, handing it over. "Your boss was seen being taken into the spire."

* * *

The Cobbler's Pot was a cobbler's shop before it was a tavern, and nobody ever took the trade down off the walls. The five of them sat at a corner table beneath rows of lasts and shoe horns, surrounded by racks of awls. It was the sort of room where people minded their own business and looked anywhere but at one another.

"How are you feeling?" Aeska had turned his chair round towards Billiam. "Are you still the same? You're okay?"

"Yeah. I'm fine, I think. Still quite tired."

"You know, there's a new kind of glow to you, Billy." Lark leaned across the table. "On your chest, maybe."

"Yes." Aeska did not smile. "I suppose you and Felix have that in common now."

"Maybe it helps you getting in control of your magic," said Felix.

"Something else might help me." Billiam put his hand up for the woman with the tray. "I'll have a beer, please."

He had never ordered one in his life. The confidence with which he did it was new, and not one of them failed to notice.

"Aren't you a bit young to drink beer?" Lark had put him at sixteen the day she met him and had never revised it. A boy of sixteen could get a beer in this city if he wanted one. He would not usually ask for one first.

"No." He did not even look round. "We're all adults."

"A round for the table, then."

"Not for me." Lark put a hand over her cup. "I don't drink."

"A round for the table," said Aeska, over the top of her and loud enough to carry. The woman with the tray heard that and not the refusal, and brought five, which left Lark sitting behind one she had not asked for.

Somehow, the conversation turned to their ages. Lark was eighteen, with ninety-five days to go until her nineteenth birthday. Calder was nineteen. Billiam was nineteen as well, which surprised him; he had always assumed Calder was several years older, and said as much.

Lark's face came apart. She had called Billiam her little brother, out loud, in front of the Porter's Guild enforcers, to get him out of the scuffle.

* * *

"I'm really curious who's targeting you, Felix." Billiam had got about a third of the way down the beer and did not like it and was finishing it anyway. "It seems someone really is looking out to get you."

"Me too."

"You don't normally meet people who haven't got a heart," Felix said. "And have something else instead."

"Do you think it's the same people who had you removed from the guild?"

"Might be related. I have no idea."

"Your colleague was targeted too." Billiam set the cup down. "The one who gave you the ledger. She got shot in a tunnel."

"She did."

"Then that's a pattern." "Mr Theodore. Then her. Now you. That's three."

"Three," Aeska said, "and whoever is doing it knows that Felix is the one who walked out of that tunnel carrying the ledger. They did not kill the secretary. They

left her alive long enough to hand it over, and they have known where it went ever since.”

“And this creature I have seen before.” Felix had been waiting to say it. “I killed one like it getting out of the place they kept me. It was smaller than this one, and it was not as dangerous, and then a second one came and I did not stay to fight it.”

“The warehouse I was in. There would be records, as well.” Felix turned his cup round. “And a warehouse in the city always has an owner. It had one before they were in it, and it probably still has one now.”

They had more than one thread to pull.

There were Alfie and Hollis. Shrapnel’s own handwriting had given them addresses for both. Hollis’s led to the Firebox, a boxing gym in the Stacks; whether he actually lived there or simply had nowhere else to put down on paper was unclear. Alfie’s place was halfway up the city.

Billiam wanted to start knocking on doors. He had stopped asking whether that was a sensible idea.

Then there was Mira, who ran the Brassline. If Evan Langford’s name had been spoken around the crews, Mira was one of the people most likely to have heard it.

And finally, Benjamin Buckman’s office at the College. Calder could get close to him in a way the others could not, which made that lead worth keeping to himself.

“And we should find out about these cores,” Aeska said. “The one in Billiam and the one in Felix. What they are. What they do to you.”

“Can I say something that’s bothering me?” Lark had not touched her beer. “The danger keeps growing. Our faces are known now, most of them, in some way, to people who want us. And we have not gathered a single ally in all this time. We are working in the shadows and hiding and avoiding.”

“That is because the shadows are where it is safe,” said Calder.

“I’m sure there are people who liked Mr Theodore. People who would help us if they just knew.” She looked round the table. “But we are not known to anybody like that, and we have never once tried.”

“I sort of agree.” Calder turned his cup. “But it is very dangerous to give out information to essentially random people. We cannot know whose side they are on. And if we give it away freely, we are worse off than before.”

“So we name one.” Lark put her hands flat on the table. “Mr Aeska, you were in the guild. Did you know anybody who was really a friend of Theo’s? Anybody with a position?”

Aeska thought about it properly, which took a while, and came back with

nothing.

“Unfortunately I do not.” He said it as though it embarrassed him. “When I was in the guild, Theo was still working his way up. He was the hard-working type, not the making-connections type.”

“Mr Felix? You were beside him a year.”

“He didn’t like that side of it.” Felix shook his head. “He was good at the work and the work paid, and he never once tried to climb. Everything else went into the talks.”

So whatever friends Theodore Blackwood made in this city, he made them downward, among people with nothing to give them, and that is why there are only five brave people sitting at this table.

* * *

“I’ll see Mira tonight,” Lark said, “and do the letter in the morning while he’s at his forge.”

“I am at Fexfield in the morning.” Felix had not touched his beer either. “I have to be. The paperwork is the only door I have.”

“And I will go and look at my supervisor’s office.” Calder said it to the table. “Only look. From the outside.”

“Then midday,” said Aeska. “All of us. And then we go and knock on two doors.”

Aeska offered to pay for a room for Lark. She tried to refuse, but he would not let her argue over it. In the end she accepted, and Aeska took a room for himself in the same place.

By the time they left, Billiam was in no state to find his own way home. He stumbled along beside Felix, words catching and breaking apart in his mouth.

“I’m f-fine,” he mumbled. “I can... I can g-get home. I just...”

He swayed hard enough that Felix caught him by the shoulder.

“Right,” Felix said. “I’m walking you home.”

Aeska turned the pocket watch over in his hands for a long while before he seemed satisfied that he understood it. He opened the casing, examined the tiny sliver of essence core set into its workings, then tested the needle again.

The watch could be given the name of a particular spell. Once set, the needle would turn towards the nearest place where that spell had been cast. It would continue pointing towards the source for an hour, regardless of how far away the casting occurred. The watch could then be passed from one person to another

without losing what it was tracking.

So whoever sent this man to the scrapyard was not following Felix. They were following his magic.

Someone in Parvo knew one of Felix's spells well enough to name it, had put that spell into the watch, and sent a man carrying it into the city. The carter had never been the target. He had only been following the needle.



Billiam reached home drunk for the first time in his life and slept badly.

Twice during the night he woke in the darkness, cold and disoriented, with no sense of what had pulled him from sleep. Each time, when he closed his eyes again, he found himself somewhere else.

There was no ground beneath his feet. No sky, no walls, no horizon. Only a vast, black emptiness stretching in every direction.

And far away, almost too distant to make out, stood a woman.

He could never see her clearly. She remained at the edge of sight, motionless and waiting. Billiam would turn towards her, trying to understand who she was, trying to reach her, and he would wake with a terrible ache in his chest.

It was grief, but deeper than grief had any right to be. The hollow certainty that he had lost something precious, something enormous, without knowing what it was or when he had lost it.

Then sleep would take him again.

And he would find himself back in the darkness, with the woman still waiting in the distance.